The Law of Graphic Equalisation — Physics Grounding

Change, c, the Reconciliation of Special and General Relativity, the Dimensional Constants, and the Second Law

Matthew Parslow
Independent Researcher

Draft — draft-2026-08-26
26 August 2026

DRAFT — draft-2026-08-26 (26 August 2026). This document is under active revision and is circulated for comment, not as a finished result. It is a companion to *The Law of Graphic Equalisation — Theory* (referred to below as Graphic Equalisation), and inherits that paper's definitions, epistemic boundary, and level-of-claims. Sections marked as falsifiability commitments are the intended points of attack.

Abstract

This companion to Graphic Equalisation develops the physics groundings of the change-substrate. Its central move is that a frame's time is an inferred count of *cycles* and that the invariant speed c is the frame's own change-throughput unit, 1 by construction rather than by postulate; from that one economy special and general relativity, the dimensional constants, and the second law follow as *shapes*. Special relativity's c-invariance becomes a theorem; special and general relativity reconcile as one fixed change-budget spent two ways, on motion or on change-load; the dimensional constants $(c, \hbar, k_{\mathrm{B}}, G)$ are each a frame's own base unit and their magnitudes are cross-frame artefacts; the uncertainty principle is the finite-aperture floor, the Landauer bound the information–energy conversion, quantization the aperture cell, and the Planck scale the frontier. The second law is no-copy accumulated, with entropy frame-relative, the demon exorcised by cost, and local order affordable as paid minting. The claims are information-level, physics taken as an embodiment: the paper mechanises the shapes and explicitly does not derive the field equations, the dimensionless constants, or a theory of quantum gravity.

1 Scope

This paper is a grounding, not a physical theory. It inherits Graphic Equalisation's position that the claims are about information — distinction, frame, admissibility, realisation — of which physical theory is one embodiment, and that a physical result bears on an information-level claim when it settles an informational fact. Everything below is at that level. The strong claims are structural: that there is a c, a $\hbar$, an uncertainty principle, a Landauer floor, a second law, and that special and general relativity reconcile as one change-economy. The weak part is anything carrying a number: no field equations, no quantitative metric, no exact Lorentz factor, no dimensionless constant, and no theory of quantum gravity. Each grounding is a *promoted* constraint exposed to falsification, in the manner of Graphic Equalisation's collapse bridge, not a result asserted from within.

2 c as the change-to-time rate

Graphic Equalisation establishes that time is not a substrate dimension but is *inferred* by a frame, whose unit is a *cycle* — one traversal of a closed rule-loop, of no fixed length. Once time is the inferred count of cycles, the invariant speed c has a natural reading, consistent with the missing-denominator result (there is no rate *in* substrate-time, since there is no substrate-time to divide by). c is the fixed *rate* at which change is realised — per unit of the substrate's throughput, a cycle consuming a variable amount of it — from which a frame's time is inferred. So c is prior to time: the conversion between change-count and inferred duration, which is exactly what a constant relating the temporal and spatial parts of an interval is.

Proposition 2.1 (c is each frame's own unit, hence invariant by construction)**.** *c is each frame's own base rate, its change-throughput, so every frame measures its own c as the unit,* 1 *— and a unit cannot be measured as anything else. Its invariance is therefore a theorem, not a postulate: not that all frames happen to agree on a speed, but that each is reporting its own unit.*

A value *other* than 1 is a cross-frame quantity: the familiar number appears only when one frame is compared with another — change-throughput against a spatial metric, seconds against metres — which is where the continuous lives, in the maps between frames rather than in a frame's own discrete states. One can give time a number at all only by comparing frames; in its own frame c is the unit, and its particular value (299 792 458 in SI) is an artefact of the comparison, not a fact about the substrate. And c is a *limit* because a signal is a sequence of changes and none can be realised faster than the frame's throughput.

3 The change-budget: speed, dilation, mass, aperture

Speed is a quantum of that unit. The fixed throughput c splits between *spatial motion* and *internal change* (proper time), and a speed is the fraction spent on motion. At rest the whole budget is internal change and the clock ticks fully; approaching c moves budget to motion, leaving less for internal change, so the clock slows — time dilation as budget re-allocation — and at c the whole budget is motion and no proper time remains. Mass is the budget *reserved* for internal change, so a massive graph can never put all of it into motion: it asymptotes to c and the energy to approach diverges, while a massless one reserves none and *is* at c, with no proper time.

Because observation is funded by internal-change throughput, approaching c coarsens a frame's *aperture*. The transformation between frames in relative motion — time dilation and length contraction — is an aperture transformation between different budget-splits, and each frame's aperture self-calibrates so that its own c still reads 1. The Lorentz factor is the aperture change that holds $c = 1$ across the split. (The constant-magnitude four-velocity of Minkowski geometry (Minkowski, 1909) is this budget-split stated as a metric fact rather than as a mechanism.)

4 Special and general relativity reconciled

The two relativities are one mechanism, because the one fixed budget c can be drained two ways.

Proposition 4.1 (SR and GR are one change-budget spent two ways)**.** *Special relativity is the budget spent on* motion*: a moving graph puts throughput into spatial motion, leaving less for internal change, so its clock slows. General relativity is the budget spent on* change-load*: mass is throughput tied up in internal change, and concentrating change-load (dense mass) consumes the local budget, so local clocks slow. Both dilations are the same act — the one fixed budget drained, by motion or by mass, each leaving less for proper time.*

The equivalence principle is the seam. Accelerating (changing one's motion) and standing in a gravitational field (change-load) draw on the budget identically, so inertial mass (resistance to a change of motion — more state to re-write, hence more change and more cost, the impulse relation of the Narrative-momentum paper with mass as the exchange rate) and gravitational mass (change-load consuming throughput and slowing local time) are one quantity, "how much change this matter loads onto the ruleset," measured two ways. General relativity assumes their equality and does not explain it; here they coincide by construction.

Corollary 4.2 (Relativity reconciles because c is defined, not postulated)**.** *Because c is here* defined *(Proposition 2.1) rather than postulated, special relativity's postulate of c-invariance becomes a theorem, and its effects follow as consequences rather than as separate surprises, with the classical paradoxes dissolving into aperture differences — each moving clock right, each reading its own $c = 1$. Special and general relativity then reconcile (Proposition 4.1) as velocity- and gravity-dilation of one budget, joined at the equivalence principle.*

5 Relativity and collapse

Relativity also reconciles with the collapse picture of quantum measurement, by a division Graphic Equalisation already carries: continuous structure lives in the maps between frames, discrete change in a frame's own states. The continuous geometry of general relativity is a cross-frame *map*; the collapse of quantum measurement is the in-frame *event*; and c — the change-to-time rate — is the seam joining the discrete event to the continuous metric. The two are the map and the event of one change-substrate, not rival ontologies, and the standing incompatibility is the artefact of treating them as rivals. This is a claim about the *shape* of the reconciliation, not a derivation: that the field equations follow is not asserted, and no theory of quantum gravity is offered.

6 The accelerator: forced concurrency and decoherence

The same c bounds concurrency, and this gives the high-energy regime a reading. Within a frame, change is self-change and strictly ordered, so forcing two changes onto one rule-step is the paid exception; a particle accelerator is the machine that pays it, spending energy to push particles' interactions to the same step, where the frame — built to sequence — cannot order them and the interaction is *decoherent* in that frame. The energy divergence as a particle approaches c is the change-rate ceiling: two changes cannot be crowded closer than a step, and forcing them there costs more the closer one gets. The strong reading is "energy is the price of forced concurrency, and forced concurrency is frame decoherence"; anything with a number is weak.

7 Dimensional constants are frame-units; dimensionless ones are not

The reading of c as a frame's own base unit generalises. Each dimensional constant is the base unit of one of a frame's own economies — 1 in-frame, a number only cross-frame.

- c is the change-rate unit (Section 2).
- $\hbar$ is the *aperture quantum*, the smallest resolvable cell: observation is funded by finite internal-change throughput, so fine resolution in one dimension trades against another and the trade floors at a minimum cell — which is the uncertainty principle, $\Delta x\, \Delta p \geq \hbar/2$ being the finite-aperture budget stated as a bound, with $\hbar$ its quantum.

- k_B is the information–energy conversion: Landauer's $k_B T \ln 2$ (Landauer, 1961) — the floor cost of change of Graphic Equalisation's economics — is one bit's change converted from the information frame into the energy frame at that rate.
- G is the change-load–geometry coupling, mass deforming the containing frame.

That physics sets $c = \hbar = k_B = G = 1$ (natural units) is then not a convenience but a recognition: these are frame-units, so they read 1 in a frame's own terms, and their familiar magnitudes are cross-frame artefacts — the frame's unit against a human metre, second, kilogram, kelvin. "Why is c that number" is a question about the comparison, not the substrate.

Proposition 7.1 (The dimensional/dimensionless boundary)**.** *This dissolves the* dimensional *constants and touches the* dimensionless *ones not at all. The fine-structure constant* $\alpha \approx 1/137$ *and the mass ratios cannot be set to* 1 *by any unit choice; they are genuine cross-frame* ratios*, real numbers with no dimension to absorb, and the framework says nothing about their values.*

It sharpens the real question rather than answering it: the numbers that need explaining are the dimensionless ones, while the pseudo-mysteries — why c, why $\hbar$ — are unit conventions. This is the standard observation that the number of fundamental *dimensional* constants is a matter of convention (Duff, 2002), landing on the side that they are units; the dimensionless remainder is left exactly as open as it was found.

8 The Planck scale, quantization, and fine-tuning

Three consequences follow. First, the *Planck scale* is where the dimensional units meet at 1 simultaneously ($\ell_P = \sqrt{\hbar G/c^3}$ and its companions): the aperture cell ($\hbar$), the change-rate ceiling (c), and the change-load–geometry coupling (G) reach their unit at once. Below it a frame cannot resolve, cannot order, and horizons its own geometry, so nothing there is representable — the "?" of Graphic Equalisation's epistemic boundary with a location. The Planck scale *is* the frontier, which is why physics predicts its own breakdown there: not a failure of theories but the exhaustion of a frame's units, below which the pre-relational substrate begins.

Second, *quantization* is the aperture being cellular: because $\hbar$ is a minimum cell rather than an infinitesimal, action and energy come in $\hbar$-steps, so the "quantum" of quantum mechanics is Graphic Equalisation's discrete sufficiency read at the resolution axis — the granularity of the aperture, not a separate granularity of the world.

Third, the *dimensionless* constants are contingent rule-content: the framework cannot derive α or the mass ratios, but it can say what kind of thing they are — the contingent specifics of this substrate's rule-set (Graphic Equalisation's nothing-compulsory principle), so "why α" is not "why this necessary value" but "why this rule-set," a question answered with contingency, since a different rule-set gives a different α at no extra machinery. This relocates fine-tuning at its root: the inference "the constants are tuned, therefore design or necessity" assumes they are the kind of thing with a necessary value, whereas the dimensional ones are units with no value to tune and the dimensionless ones are contingent, so their being tunable is expected rather than remarkable.

9 The second law

Entropy and its arrow follow from the same economy.

Definition 9.1 (Entropy is what a frame does not distinguish)**.** *The entropy a frame holds is the log-count of the microstructure it carries but cannot tell apart — what falls below its aperture. Entropy is therefore frame- and aperture-relative from the start: a finer aperture resolves more and reads less entropy, a coarser one more.*

This is the Gibbs–Jaynes reading, in which entropy is a property of the observer's coarse-graining rather than of the world in itself (Jaynes, 1957); here it is grounded rather than assumed — entropy is *what this frame does not distinguish.*

Proposition 9.2 (The second law is no-copy accumulated)**.** *Every change discards its predecessor — the prior state goes* NULL *unless paid to keep — so each change pushes structure below the aperture, into the un-distinguished. Change therefore accumulates entropy, because change forgets by default and forgetting is exactly this demotion. The arrow of entropy is the no-copy asymmetry, which is the same asymmetry as accumulated change-cost (the Landauer floors summing) and as causation (a change enables its successor, not its predecessor). Equivalently, entropy is accumulated un-absorbed residual: what no grammar mints stays un-distinguished, so residual piling up is entropy rising.*

Corollary 9.3 (The demon is exorcised, and local order is affordable)**.** *Because* k_{B} *converts entropy to energy, Landauer's* $k_{\mathrm{B}}T\ln 2$ *is the price of* resolving *one bit — dragging one distinction up out of the un-distinguished, or erasing one back down. Maxwell's demon is exorcised by exactly this: it must pay to distinguish, and that payment is the entropy it thought it removed for free (Bennett, 1982). There is no free distinction, hence no free entropy reduction. Yet local entropy reduction is possible: minting resolves residual and builds structure, but it is a write, so it is paid, and the payment is Landauer heat exported to the surroundings — local order bought by global entropy increase. This is Schrödinger's "life feeds on negentropy" (Schrödinger, 1944) grounded: an organism, a learner, a growing graph is a region that pays to mint local structure and dumps the cost as heat. Life does not violate the second law; it is the second law with a subsidy.*

Remark (The arrows unify)*.* The thermodynamic arrow (entropy up), the causal arrow (change enables forward), and the psychological arrow (memory is present structure of a discarded past) are not three arrows that happen to align; they are one, the no-copy accumulation of change. Every "why do they agree" puzzle in the arrow-of-time literature is asking why three descriptions of a single asymmetry point the same way, and they do because the asymmetry is one: change does not keep its predecessor.

10 Identical particles are functional identity

Graphic Equalisation's Axiom −1 holds that two things with no difference that makes a difference are the same, and its no-frame-free-identity theorem that one cannot say which of two is which independently of an individuating frame. This is the quantum treatment of identical particles exactly: two electrons carry no label, and "which is which" names no difference and so has no content. Classical physics labels identical objects — treats two identical bodies as distinct in principle — and that label is a fiction, a distinction imposed where none exists.

Proposition 10.1 (Quantum statistics, and the Gibbs paradox, are functional identity)**.** *Classical Maxwell–Boltzmann counting labels identical particles and over-counts arrangements; quantum Bose–Einstein and Fermi–Dirac counting treats them as one where they are indistinguishable. The Gibbs paradox — the spurious entropy of mixing two identical gases — resolves by not labelling them, which is Axiom* −1*, and ties to Section 9: entropy is what a frame distinguishes, so identical particles, having nothing to distinguish, add no mixing entropy. The* $1/N!$ *Gibbs correction is functional identity made quantitative.*

Corollary 10.2 (Pauli exclusion is "distinct things need a distinction")**.** *If two fermions were in the same state — the same in every quantum number — they would carry no distinguishing distinction, and by Axiom* −1 *would be one, not two. To be two they must differ somewhere. The exclusion principle is therefore the requirement that distinct things be distinguishable: there*

is no such thing as two indistinguishables in one state, because that "two" names no difference. Exclusion is the arithmetic of identity, not a force.

Remark (The honest limit: spin–statistics). Indistinguishability and fermion exclusion are clean here; the boson side is not. Why bosons pile into one state as a count while fermions cap at one, and the minus sign under exchange tied to a 2π rotation, is the spin–statistics theorem, which needs structure this account does not supply. The framework grounds *that* particles are indistinguishable and *why* fermions exclude, and hands the boson/sign/spin–statistics content back untouched — the same shape/number division as elsewhere.

11 Positioning and prior art

The pieces are individually established; the contribution is the conjunction under one change-economy and the mechanisation of shapes prior art postulates, geometrises, or offers heuristically.

Deriving c, and mass as internal motion. That c should be *derived* rather than postulated has precedent by a different route. Ignatowsky (Ignatowsky, 1911) and, cleanly, Lévy-Leblond (Lévy-Leblond, 1976) obtain the Lorentz transformation from the relativity principle together with homogeneity, isotropy, and group structure alone, with an invariant speed *emerging* rather than assumed and its value left empirical; those derivations use symmetry as the engine where the present one uses the change-substrate — c as each frame's own change-throughput unit, 1 by construction. The reading of mass as the budget reserved for internal change has two standing precedents, offered heuristically rather than mechanised: Schrödinger's *zitterbewegung*, the electron's rest energy as internal motion at c (Schrödinger, 1930), developed as a rest-mass-from-internal- circulation interpretation by Hestenes (Hestenes, 1990); and the elementary result that confined massless radiation — light in a box — carries rest mass E/c^2, internalised c-motion appearing as inertia. The budget-split itself is the constant-magnitude four-velocity of Minkowski geometry (Minkowski, 1909).

Relativity as postulate. Einstein's special (Einstein, 1905) and general (Einstein, 1916) relativity take c-invariance and the equivalence principle as postulates; the present account renders the first a theorem (Proposition 2.1) and the second a common cause (Section 4), at the cost of claiming only the shapes.

Entropy and the demon. The observer-relative reading of entropy is Jaynes's (Jaynes, 1957); the resolution of Maxwell's demon by the cost of information is Landauer's and Bennett's (Landauer, 1961; Bennett, 1982); life as locally paid negentropy is Schrödinger's (Schrödinger, 1944). The present account ties all three to one substrate law — cost is the write.

Dimensional constants. That the count of fundamental *dimensional* constants is conventional is Duff's position in the Duff–Okun–Veneziano exchange (Duff, 2002); the present account gives the reason (they are frame-units) and draws the boundary at the dimensionless remainder.

12 Falsifiability commitments

Each is exposed to attack; the scope caveat of Section 1 applies throughout.

1. c **as frame-unit.** Fails if a frame can measure its own base change-rate as anything other than 1, or if c-invariance requires a postulate that cannot be recovered as the unit reading.

2. **One budget, two dilations.** Fails if velocity time dilation and gravitational time dilation cannot be exhibited as the same fixed budget spent on motion and on change-load respectively — if the equivalence principle is not their common cause here.

3. **Dimensional/dimensionless boundary.** Fails if a genuinely dimensionless constant can be set to 1 by unit choice, or if a dimensional constant carries an irreducible value not absorbable into a frame's units.

4. **Second law as no-copy.** Fails if entropy can rise in a frame whose changes preserve their predecessors, or fall in one without a paid write exporting cost.

5. **Indistinguishability is functional identity.** Fails if identical particles carry a frame-free label distinguishing them, or if the Gibbs $1/N!$ correction and Fermi exclusion cannot be read as "distinct things require a distinguishing distinction." (The boson/spin–statistics content is not claimed.)

6. **Scope.** The paper claims shapes only; it is falsified as *overclaiming* if any passage is read to derive a field equation, a dimensionless constant, or a quantum-gravity result — none is asserted.

References

Charles H. Bennett. The thermodynamics of computation — a review. *International Journal of Theoretical Physics*, 21(12):905–940, 1982.

Michael J. Duff. Comment on time-variation of fundamental constants. arXiv:hep-th/0208093, 2002. (Duff–Okun–Veneziano, "Trialogue on the number of fundamental constants.")

Albert Einstein. Zur Elektrodynamik bewegter Körper. *Annalen der Physik*, 322(10):891–921, 1905.

Albert Einstein. Die Grundlage der allgemeinen Relativitätstheorie. *Annalen der Physik*, 354(7):769–822, 1916.

David Hestenes. The zitterbewegung interpretation of quantum mechanics. *Foundations of Physics*, 20(10):1213–1232, 1990.

Wladimir A. von Ignatowsky. Einige allgemeine Bemerkungen zum Relativitätsprinzip. *Physikalische Zeitschrift*, 11:972–976, 1911.

Edwin T. Jaynes. Information theory and statistical mechanics. *Physical Review*, 106:620–630, 1957.

Rolf Landauer. Irreversibility and heat generation in the computing process. *IBM Journal of Research and Development*, 5(3):183–191, 1961.

Jean-Marc Lévy-Leblond. One more derivation of the Lorentz transformation. *American Journal of Physics*, 44(3):271–277, 1976.

Hermann Minkowski. Raum und Zeit. *Physikalische Zeitschrift*, 10:75–88, 1909. Address delivered 1908.

Erwin Schrödinger. Über die kräftefreie Bewegung in der relativistischen Quantenmechanik. *Sitzungsberichte der Preussischen Akademie der Wissenschaften, Physikalisch-mathematische Klasse*, 24:418–428, 1930.

Erwin Schrödinger. *What Is Life? The Physical Aspect of the Living Cell.* Cambridge University Press, Cambridge, 1944.